

Imagery and the Five Senses — Part 1

Name: _____

Date: _____

Time: **15 min**

1 · COPY THIS DOWN — NAMING IMAGERY

DEFINITION

Imagery is descriptive language that appeals to the senses, so the reader can picture, hear, smell, taste, or feel what is being described, instead of just being told about it.

THE TECHNIQUE — NAME THE SENSE

1. Find a descriptive phrase in the passage
2. Ask: which sense does this appeal to? (there can be more than one)
3. Name the correct type of imagery
4. Explain the effect: what does this imagery make the reader picture or feel?

THE 5 MAIN TYPES (PLUS 2 EXTRAS WORTH KNOWING)

TYPE	SENSE	EXAMPLE
Visual	Sight	"the sky bruised purple at the edges"
Auditory	Sound	"the gate shrieked on its hinges"
Olfactory	Smell	"the sharp tang of vinegar hung in the air"
Gustatory	Taste	"the bitter aftertaste of burnt toast"
Tactile	Touch	"the rope was rough and biting against her palms"
Kinaesthetic (<i>stretch</i>)	Movement	"his legs buckled beneath him"
Organic (<i>stretch</i>)	Internal feeling	"a knot tightened in her stomach"

2 · WORKED EXAMPLE

"Smoke curled through the kitchen, catching in the back of her throat, while somewhere a pan hissed and spat on the stove."

VISUAL "smoke curled" — the reader pictures the shape and movement of the smoke

OLFACTORY / TACTILE "catching in the back of her throat" — a smell strong enough to be felt physically

AUDITORY "hissed and spat" — onomatopoeia, letting the reader hear the pan

EFFECT Three senses stacked together make the kitchen feel chaotic and slightly dangerous, before any character even speaks.

3 · PRACTICE PASSAGE

1 The orchard in late September smelled of windfall apples turning soft in the grass, sweet and slightly fermented. Wasps droned low over the fallen fruit, and every few seconds one would land on Theo's arm, its legs impossibly light against his skin, before lifting off again.

2 He could taste the dust in the air, dry and metallic at the back of his mouth, kicked up by his own boots on the cracked earth. Somewhere behind the far hedge, his grandfather's saw rasped through a branch, on and off, on and off, a sound Theo had grown up falling asleep to on summer afternoons like this one.

1. Find one example of olfactory imagery in paragraph 1 and explain its effect.

2. "Its legs impossibly light against his skin" is an example of which type of imagery? Justify your answer.

3. Identify one example of gustatory imagery in paragraph 2.

4. The saw is described as sound that "rasped... on and off, on and off." What effect does repeating this auditory image have?

5. Using evidence from at least two different senses, explain what overall mood this passage creates.

Apply this every time: Whenever a question asks "how does the writer create a sense of ____" or "what imagery is used," always name the exact type (visual/auditory/olfactory/gustatory/tactile), quote the phrase, and explain the effect — never just say "descriptive language" without naming it.

MARKING NOTES (FOR THE TUTOR)

- Q1:** "smelled of windfall apples turning soft... sweet and slightly fermented" — creates a warm, slightly overripe late-summer atmosphere.
- Q2:** Tactile — describes physical sensation of the wasp's legs on skin.
- Q3:** "could taste the dust... dry and metallic at the back of his mouth."
- Q4:** The repetition mimics the rhythm of the sawing itself and creates a steady, familiar, almost lulling background sound, tying to the nostalgic mood of the final sentence.
- Q5:** Should identify a nostalgic/peaceful late-summer mood, citing at least two senses (e.g. smell of apples + sound of the saw) as evidence.